

Prompt Like a Pro

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The first skill everyone needs. How to ask AI a question the way you would ask a thoughtful expert - and get an answer that actually helps.

Why Prompting Matters

AI tools are only as useful as the questions you give them. A vague question gets a vague answer. A clear, specific prompt gets something you can actually use. The good news: prompting is a learnable skill.

The 4-Part Prompt Formula

Every strong prompt has four elements. You do not need all four every time - but knowing them changes how you think:

>> ROLE

Tell the AI who to be. Example: 'You are a patient teacher explaining this to a curious teenager.'

>> TASK

State what you want. Be specific. 'Write a 3-sentence summary of...' beats 'Summarize this.'

>> CONTEXT

Give the background it needs. Who is this for? What do you already know? What constraints exist?

>> FORMAT

Say how you want the output. 'Give me a numbered list' or 'Keep it under 100 words' both work.

Prompt Starters You Can Use Today

For learning:

'Explain [topic] to me like I am new to it. Use an everyday analogy.'

For writing:

'Help me rewrite this paragraph to sound more confident and clear: [paste your text]'

For decisions:

'I am trying to decide between [A] and [B]. Here is my situation: [context]. What are the trade-offs?'

For planning:

'I have [X hours/days] to [accomplish goal]. What is a realistic step-by-step plan?'

For feedback:

'Read this and tell me what is unclear, what is missing, and what is strongest: [paste your work]'

Common Mistakes (and the Fix)

Too vague

Instead of: Just typing: 'Tell me about marketing'

Try: Add context: 'I run a small tutoring business. What are 3 low-cost ways to find new students?'

No role set

Instead of: Just typing: 'Write a bio'

Try: Specify: 'Write a 2-sentence bio for my LinkedIn profile. I am a teacher moving into curriculum design.'

One-shot thinking

Instead of: Accepting the first answer and moving on

Try: Follow up: 'Make it shorter' / 'Add an example' / 'Try a different tone' - the conversation is the skill.

Your Practice Prompt

Open any AI tool. Use this template:

>> PRACTICE

You are a helpful coach. I want to get better at [one skill you are working on]. Ask me 3 questions to understand where I am, then suggest one small next step I can take this week.

Notice how it feels different from typing 'help me with [skill].' That difference - that is the skill.